

Breaking the Experience Paradox: FirstStep, a Web-Based
Platform for Job Seekers
Without Experience

Author: Quisha Amanda U. Modequillo
Program: Bachelor of Science in Nursing 4D
Date: August 20, 2026

I. Introduction

Entering the workforce is an important transition, yet securing a first job can be difficult for individuals with little or no professional experience. Fresh graduates, first-time job seekers, people who had limited opportunities, people who did not receive the education they deserved, and other individuals beginning their careers may encounter employment opportunities that require prior work experience. This creates what may be described as an experience paradox: individuals need work experience to become more competitive for employment, but they first need employment opportunities in order to gain that experience.

This challenge exists within a broader global issue of youth employment. The International Labor Organization (ILO) reported that 64.9 million young people aged 15–24 were unemployed worldwide in 2023, representing a global youth unemployment rate of 13%. In the same year, approximately 20% of young people were not in employment, education, or training (NEET). Although global youth unemployment had improved, the ILO emphasized that many young people continue to face difficulties accessing secure and decent work.

The problem is also relevant in the Philippine setting. The Department of Labor and Employment's JobStart Philippines program specifically supports young people with no or limited work experience by providing career coaching, skills training, internships, and employment facilitation. The existence of programs such as JobStart demonstrates the recognized need to help young people transition from education or unemployment into the world of work.

However, existing employment platforms generally contain job opportunities for applicants with varying levels of experience. For first-time job seekers, navigating numerous job advertisements and identifying positions that genuinely accept applicants without professional experience can be difficult. An employment platform specifically designed to prioritize people at the beginning of their careers could help address this gap.

This project, therefore, proposes FirstStep, a technology-enabled employment website designed primarily for job seekers without professional work experience. The platform aims to connect inexperienced yet capable individuals with employers who are willing to provide genuine entry-level opportunities, training, and professional growth.

Problem Description

The central problem addressed by this project is the limited accessibility and visibility of genuine employment opportunities for job seekers without prior professional experience.

For many individuals entering the workforce, the lack of prior employment can be a significant barrier in the job search process. First-time job seekers may possess educational qualifications, technical knowledge, transferable skills, volunteer experience, academic projects, or a willingness to learn, but they may still be disadvantaged when competing against applicants with established work histories. The issue is particularly important for young people.

According to the ILO, young people continue to experience significant challenges in the labor market, and in 2023, approximately one-fifth of the world's youth were classified as NEET (Number of Youth Not in Employment, Education, or Training (NEET) a Cause for Concern, Despite Falling Jobless Rate | Division for Inclusive Social Development (DISD), n.d). The ILO also notes that access to secure and decent employment remains unequal, particularly in developing economies (Global Employment Trends for Youth 2024: In Figures, 2025). The Philippine government has similarly recognized the difficulty of transitioning into employment without sufficient work exposure. Through JobStart Philippines, eligible young people, including those with no work experience or less than one year of accumulated work experience, are provided with training, internships, and employment facilitation (Cruz, 2024). The program's design reflects the importance of providing practical work opportunities to individuals who have not yet had the chance to establish professional experience.

The problem is not necessarily that all employers should eliminate experience requirements. Certain positions legitimately require previous knowledge, training, or professional expertise. However, difficulties arise when inexperienced job seekers have limited access to a clearly identified space where employers are actively seeking beginners and are prepared to train them. Therefore, there is a need for a more focused digital solution that does not merely list available jobs but prioritizes opportunities genuinely accessible to individuals without professional experience.

II. Proposed Solution

To address this problem, the project proposes FirstStep, a web-based employment platform specifically designed for individuals with zero professional work experience.

The mission of FirstStep is to provide first-time job seekers with a dedicated digital space where they can search for employment opportunities without being immediately excluded because they lack a previous employment history. The platform will connect these individuals with employers who are willing to hire, train, mentor, and support emerging employees.

The platform's core features include a job board that prioritizes zero-experience positions, allowing employers to post qualifying opportunities for free as long as the roles do not require prior professional experience, are suitable for first-time job seekers, clearly indicate training or onboarding provisions, and avoid contradictory requirements such as being labeled "entry-level" while still demanding years of experience, with eligible postings receiving a "FirstStep Verified" badge for easy identification; it also includes an experience requirement monitoring system that reviews and flags inconsistent job descriptions, such as when a "no experience required" listing still demands several years of work history, to ensure reliability for applicants; an employer incentive and subscription model further supports the platform by offering free postings for zero-experience roles while charging for positions requiring prior experience, which do not receive priority or verification status, thereby encouraging more beginner-friendly opportunities and generating revenue for platform maintenance and development; in addition, FirstStep provides potential-based job seeker profiles that highlight education, skills, academic projects, volunteer work, organizational involvement, certifications, portfolios, and career goals instead of focusing solely on employment history, enabling employers to assess applicants based on potential and capability; finally, it offers career preparation and growth tools such as résumé-building assistance, interview preparation resources, workplace-readiness guides, career exploration support, and skill-development recommendations, aligning with broader efforts like the Philippine JobStart program to

support individuals transitioning into employment, ultimately positioning FirstStep as a digital starting point for individuals ready to work but still seeking their first professional experience.

III. Conclusion

The transition from education or unemployment into the workforce can be challenging, particularly for individuals without prior professional experience. While work experience can be valuable to employers, first-time job seekers face a fundamental difficulty when they are expected to demonstrate experience before being given their first opportunity to obtain it.

This challenge exists within the broader global issue of youth employment. Although youth unemployment has improved in recent years, millions of young people remain unemployed, and approximately one-fifth of the global youth population was not in employment, education, or training in 2023. These figures demonstrate the continuing importance of creating accessible pathways from education and unemployment into meaningful work.

FirstStep proposes a technology-enabled response by creating a dedicated employment platform that prioritizes job seekers with zero professional experience. Through verified zero-experience job postings, experience-requirement monitoring, employer incentives, potential-based profiles, and career preparation tools, the platform aims to reduce unnecessary barriers between inexperienced individuals and their first employment opportunity.

The purpose of FirstStep is not to suggest that experience is unimportant. Rather, it recognizes that every experienced employee was once an inexperienced individual who needed someone to provide a first opportunity.

By connecting potential with opportunity, FirstStep seeks to help first-time job seekers begin their professional journeys, gain the experience they need, and grow into capable and experienced members of the workforce.

FirstStep: Where potential gets its first opportunity.

IV. References

Cruz, E. (n.d.). JobStart Philippines Program - Youth Employment Exchange.

<https://jobstart.philjobnet.gov.ph/#:~:text=Filipino%20citizen.%2018%2D24%20years%20old%20at%20the,and%20full%2Dtime%20work%20in%20the%20formal%20sector.>

Global Employment Trends for Youth 2024: In figures. (2025, July 1). International Labour Organization.

[https://www.ilo.org/resource/article/global-employment-trends-youth-2024-figures#:~:text=16%20August%202024.%20Global%20Employment%20Trends%20for,employment%2C%20education%20or%20training\)%20globally%20are%20women.](https://www.ilo.org/resource/article/global-employment-trends-youth-2024-figures#:~:text=16%20August%202024.%20Global%20Employment%20Trends%20for,employment%2C%20education%20or%20training)%20globally%20are%20women.)

Number of youth not in employment, education, or training (NEET) a cause for concern, despite falling jobless rate | Division for Inclusive Social Development (DISD). (n.d.).

<https://social.desa.un.org/sdn/youth-employment#:~:text=Globally%2C%20more%20than%20half%20of%20young%20workers,also%20the%20most%20educated%20youth%20cohort%20ever.>